



Kitchen Appliances Get A Technology Makeover

Over the years, touch screens and the Internet of Things (IoT) have become immensely popular as the cost of producing them has decreased. The touch buttons, sliders, and wheels used in kitchen appliances have become a good substitute for mechanical buttons and knobs, as they are more reliable and also reduce the overall cost of the system

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Touch screens on washing machines or refrigerators were just concepts as recently as five years ago. Concepts that induced a 'wow' factor at events such as the annual Consumer Electronics Show held in Las Vegas were a demonstration of the capabilities and vision of the exhibiting electronics companies. Today, home appliances have taken the leap and touch screens and the Internet of Things are increasingly evident in the common places as the cost of producing them is decreasing every day. Internet connectivity has become more affordable, its reach is ever-expanding and appliances are now being augmented with app-enabled features such as the human machine interface (HMI), without compromising on the aesthetics and being more environmental friendly.

Bringing capacitive touch technology to appliances

Mechanical buttons in kitchen and home appliances were not durable or very user friendly as they would break or stick to the user's fingers with time. Grease and water are common factors in kitchens, and mechanical buttons were not adaptable to these substances. Capacitive touch buttons, sliders and wheels are a good substitute to these buttons and knobs, as they are more reliable and also reduce the overall cost of the system. Touch sensors located beneath or behind a glass or plastic surface also make it easier to clean the surface and allow for more aesthetic and stylish design options (See Fig. 1).

HMI capacitive touch screens on appliances have the same advantages as touch



Fig. 1: Touch screen buttons and sliders (a) are already popular on appliances, but a refrigerator (b) with a large display to interface with the Internet provides a minimal, functional yet elegant look using touch screen technology